of intelligence did not seem to have been shared and, despite the ever increasing strafing from the cantonment walls, the terrified remains of the sepoy column battled with the women and children of the camp followers to cross by the new gun-carriage bridge. As a result, by late afternoon, as the sun was sinking behind the mountains and the shadows fast lengthening, the bank of the river had turned into ‘a swamp encrusted with ice’, and was so slippery as to be impossible for the baggage camels even to get close. As the fire from the ramparts increased in accuracy and intensity, tents, barrels of gunpowder, boxes of musket balls, packs of clothing and food were all abandoned in great piles on the banks of the Kabul River, the discarded sacks and saddlebags illuminated by the light of the now blazing cantonment. The rearguard was also forced to spike two of the nine guns the British had been allowed to take away with them, finding it impossible to drag the heavy cannon through the snow. In the end, such was the panic that almost none of the baggage made it over the bridge. So was repeated for a second time the biggest mistake made by Elphinstone at the start of the siege: failing to safeguard his commissariat.

‘Night had now closed around,’ remembered Eyre, ‘but the ghazis, having fired the Residency, and almost every building in the cantonment, the conflagration illuminated the surrounding countryside for several miles about, presenting a spectacle of fearful sublimity.’[26] As the temperature dropped ever lower after sunset, the main body of troops were by now waiting in vain for the arrival of their food, wood and tents at the camping place of Bagramee, seven miles further on. As the hours passed, and the night grew darker and colder, word began to spread that the baggage and food were lost. Within a few hours of the retreat beginning the force had yet again lost all its supplies.

At Bagramee that night, chaos ruled. The last of the rearguard did not make it in until 2 a.m., having ‘had to fight the whole way, and pass through literally a continuous line of poor wretches, men, women and children, dead or dying from the cold and wounds, who, unable to move, entreated their comrades to kill them and put an end to their misery’.[27] Right up until the entrance to the camp the rearguard found ‘scores of worn out sepoys and camp followers lining the way, having sat down in despair to perish in the snow’.

Only a lucky few had anything to eat that night. George Lawrence succeeded in finding ‘a little cold meat and sherry’, which he was given by